CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Reading Guide

Last updated: 2026-10-19

About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. It uses several AI models from competing labs, running on different platforms. One model gathers the current claims on a topic, a different one checks each claim against its source, and disagreements are kept, not smoothed over. The aim is an even-handed account that no outside party has shaped. AI makes mistakes, and so does the system built around it. We find and fix some in every cycle, so the methods keep changing and the content should improve over time. Updates come at least quarterly, sooner if something major happens.

The CA/Browser Forum decides what a publicly trusted certificate may contain, how its holder must be checked, and how long it may live. Its decisions reach almost every encrypted connection on the internet, and they are made in public by a body most people have never heard of. This collection follows that body and the browser root programs that enforce its rules [1].

The collection has six parts. Every part stands on its own, and every statement carries a numbered citation to a public source. Where two sources disagree, the disagreement is reported rather than resolved. This edition replaces the one of 1 September, and it is refreshed each week that the Forum's public record shows a change.

1. How To Read a Forum Decision

One distinction governs this whole subject, and getting it wrong is the most common error in reporting on the Forum.

A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a rule. The Forum's decisions move through five states, and only the last two bind anyone.

A ballot is first **proposed**, drafted and argued in a discussion period of at least seven days. It then enters a **voting** period of seven days. If it passes it is **adopted**, which starts a 30-day intellectual property review. Only after that review does the text **publish** into a numbered version of a guideline. A separate effective date decides when it is **in force**, and that date is often a year or more after publication.

The practical consequence is that three different true statements can be made about the same ballot, and only one of them means certificate authorities must do anything. This collection states the stage every time. Where a requirement has a future effective date, that date is given.

The unit that carries through all of it is the ballot identifier. Those identifiers are stable and prefixed by working group, so SC is the Server Certificate group, CSC is Code Signing, SMC is S/MIME, NS is Network Security, and FORUM is Forum-level governance [2].

2. The Parts

Each part covers one working group or one enforcement layer.

Part 1, Server Certificate Working Group. The busiest group, governing the certificates that secure websites. It covers the ballots and document versions, domain control validation, and certificate profiles, including the schedule that is cutting certificate lifetimes toward 47 days by 2029. This is the part to read first if you only read one.

Part 2, Code Signing Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign software. A smaller group, with one ballot in its vote and one that has not moved since spring.

Part 3, S/MIME Working Group. The rules for certificates that sign and encrypt email. It is the one place in the Forum where post-quantum algorithms are already permitted in published requirements, and it is now working on composite signatures.

Part 4, Public Trust Programs. The enforcement layer. Mozilla, Google, Microsoft and Apple each decide who is actually trusted, and their policies routinely demand more than the Forum does, earlier. This part covers their post-quantum plans, the incident record and the largest revocation of the autumn.

Part 5, Revocation and Transparency. The two mechanisms for recovering from a certificate that should not exist. Revocation is being replaced rather than repaired, and transparency is undergoing its first architectural change since it was standardized.

Part 6, Governance, Network Security and Standards. New in this edition. It covers the Forum's officers and elections, the network security requirements, and the IETF standards and audit regimes the guidelines depend on.

3. What This Collection Does Not Cover

Scope boundaries, stated so that an absence is not read as a finding.

Post-quantum algorithm standardization belongs to a separate collection. This collection records what the Forum permits in a certificate, not how the underlying algorithms are chosen or specified. Part 6 follows the IETF only where a draft becoming a standard changes what the Forum's documents may cite.

Each part records its own gaps in the relevant section, rather than leaving them silent. Where a Forum web page lags its own mailing list, the list is treated as the record and the lag is reported.

Sources

1. CA/Browser Forum - CA/Browser Forum - https://cabforum.org/ - as of 2026-10-19
2. All CA/Browser Forum Ballots - CA/Browser Forum - https://cabforum.org/ballots/ - as of 2026-10-19